



United States
Attorney's Office
Eastern District of Missouri



St. Louis Area Doctor Sentenced, Ordered to Repay \$742,000

Wednesday, February 19, 2025

For Immediate Release

U.S. Attorney's Office, Eastern District of Missouri

ST. LOUIS – U.S. District Judge Stephen R. Clark on Wednesday sentenced a doctor who ran two urgent care centers in the St. Louis area to 35 months in prison for defrauding Medicare and Missouri Medicaid and ordered him to repay \$742,528.

Dr. Sonny Saggarr, 57, will also be on supervised release for three years after he leaves prison.

Saggarr pleaded guilty in U.S. District Court in St. Louis in August to one count of conspiracy. He admitted that while operating St. Louis General Hospital (SLGH) locations in downtown St. Louis and near Creve Coeur, he and his office manager hired assistant physicians (APs) to see patients but billed Medicare and Missouri Medicaid as if Dr. Saggarr had seen them, even when he was out of town. APs are medical school graduates who have not completed a residency program. To legally practice medicine in Missouri, they are required to be closely supervised by a licensed physician under written collaborative practice arrangements (CPAs) that restrict the AP's ability to provide medical services and limit their practice areas to medically underserved rural or urban areas.

Dr. Saggarr admitted hiring "numerous" APs from July 2018 to July 2023 to work at the SLGH locations, which he and office manager Renita Barringer advertised as both urgent and primary care facilities and as a "residency prep" program and a "stepping stone" for the APs. Dr. Saggarr admitted that APs were not properly trained or supervised and that he and Barringer advised them to consult each other on their medical questions. One physician can legally supervise no more than six APs, so Dr. Saggarr offered stipends of up to \$480 per month to various physicians to induce them to sign up to be collaborating physicians, and then submitted CPA forms to the Missouri Board of Registration for the Healing Arts to falsely make it appear as if the APs were being properly supervised. He admitted that the Creve Coeur location is not medical underserved and thus APs are not permitted to work there.

Finally, Dr. Saggarr admitted that in January of 2022, he hired a doctor who had been indicted in another case to be the sole collaborating physician at the Creve Coeur location but did not disclose to Medicaid

that the co-conspirator was performing services there. That physician’s billing privileges with Medicaid had been suspended.

The conduct of Dr. Saggar and Barringer caused a loss to Medicare and Missouri Medicaid of \$742,528.

"Today's sentencing underscores our commitment to ensuring that providers are held accountable for submitting fraudulent claims for financial gain and for deliberately concealing critical information about healthcare professionals," said Special Agent in Charge Linda T. Hanley of the U.S. Department of Health and Human Services Office of Inspector General (HHS-OIG). "HHS-OIG, in partnership with the U.S. Attorney's Office and other law enforcement agencies, will continue working together to safeguard the integrity of the Medicare and Medicaid programs."

"This crime went beyond bilking taxpayer funded healthcare programs. Dr. Sonny Saggar risked the well-being of patients with urgent medical needs. He knew his assistant physicians were not qualified to see patients without supervision," said Special Agent in Charge Ashley Johnson of the FBI St. Louis Division. "To add further insult to injury, Dr. Saggar falsely claimed he was the one who saw the patients so he could bill Medicare and Medicaid."

"Doctors are expected to follow a certain code of conduct and obey the laws and regulations put in place to protect their clients," DEA St. Louis Division Special Agent in Charge Michael Davis said. "Our investigation shows that Dr. Saggar broke with protocol and endangered lives with his negligence. As a result of his misconduct, he was arrested, surrendered his DEA Certificate of Registration, can no longer prescribe controlled substances and faces nearly three years in federal prison."

Barringer, 51, pleaded guilty in December to one count of conspiracy. She is scheduled to be sentenced on April 22.

The U.S. Department of Health and Human Services Office of Inspector General, the FBI, the Drug Enforcement Administration and the Missouri Attorney General's Medicaid Fraud Control Unit investigated this case. Assistant U.S. Attorney Amy Sestric is prosecuting the case.

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Updated August 12, 2026

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